

THE FIRST ANGELINOS

The Gabrielino Indians of Los Angeles

By

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CHAPTER 11

VOICES FROM THE PAST

The study of the Gabrielino and their culture has enriched our understanding of the vital role these Indians played in the history of Los Angeles. This knowledge has also challenged some of the basic assumptions underlying traditional theories of cultural evolution. Many of these theories have been based on studies of early food-producing societies; in fact, agriculture has generally been regarded as the primary stimulus for advanced cultural developments such as calendars, astronomy, and complex systems of ritual and ceremony (Hudson 1988).

The Gabrielino did not practice agriculture; instead, their economy was based solely upon hunting and gathering. Nonetheless, these Indians possessed solar and lunar calendars, a well-developed astronomy, and an elaborate cycle of seasonal rituals. They also created a sophisticated theology centered on the supernatural being *Chengiichngech* and a viable system of economic exchange based upon a standardized shell-bead currency. These impressive achievements not only underscore the sophistication of Gabrielino society, but also suggest that both historically and functionally such cultural advances were not dependent on the prior appearance of agriculture and may, in fact, have been present in some early hunting-gathering societies elsewhere in the world.

Each year new research increases our knowledge of this fascinating people. Archaeological investigations, especially those on the Channel Islands where the impact of southern California's tremendous population growth has been less severe, continue to improve our understanding of Gabrielino settlement and subsistence patterns. These studies may one day also provide a more complete picture of the early maritime cultures that preceded the First Angelinos on these islands. Future ethnographic research will rely heavily upon the mission registers and other sources of

archival data to expand our understanding of Gabrielino political and economic organization during the historic period.

Historical and archival research will also provide a clearer picture of the decline of Gabrielino society in the years following 1852. The history of the Gabrielino in those years is one of a creative, resolute people struggling to survive in the face of overwhelming acculturation. The lives of two individuals caught in this cultural cross fire are vivid examples of the struggle many of these Indians faced in the middle to late 1800s.

JUANA MARÍA: THE LONE WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS ISLAND

The central character of the first biography is Juana María, the fabled "Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island." The tale of her 18 years of solitude on San Nicolas and her rescue in 1853 has been reported by a number of early writers (see O'Dell 1960; Heizer and Elsasser 1961). Many details of this story remain cloudy; nothing, however, can diminish the drama of the Robinson Crusoe-like ordeal of Juana María.

Her story begins in the early years of the 1800s, when European and American fur companies began sending hunting parties to the Channel Islands to gather sea otter pelts. These hunters, variously described as "Kodiaks" or "Russian Indians," were brought from Alaska and landed on the islands for extended periods of time. As many as three hunting ships were in the vicinity of San Nicolas during the years 1810-1811, and according to one account 30 hunters may have been camped on the island (Warner 1856; Taylor 1860b; Woodward 1957:253-255; Phelps 1961).

Conflicts between the Nicoleño and the "Russian Indians" arose when the latter tried to procure Nicoleño women. One account states that the hunters killed all but seven of the Nicoleño men, while another reports that the Nicoleño women avenged the deaths of their husbands by murdering all of the Russian Indians in their sleep. Ultimately, however, the Nicoleño were unable to defend themselves from further attacks and they agreed to relocate to the mainland. The priests at Mission Santa Barbara are credited with dispatching a schooner called the *Peor es Nada* to San Nicolas in 1835 to remove the islanders. The ship arrived at the island on August 3rd or 4th; the surviving Indians were gathered on the shore. Estimates of the number of Nicoleño removed from the island vary widely, from as few as four to as many as 20 (Taylor 1860b; Hardacre 1880; Nidever 1937:37-38; Woodward 1957:254-255; Phelps 1961).

While the Indians were waiting to board the ship a sudden storm arose, and in the urgency of the evacuation a young woman in her mid-20s was left on the island. The circumstances of her abandonment are unclear. One account states that she was gathering plant foods in the island's interior when the ship departed. Another says that she left the boarding party at the shore and returned home to find her child, who had accidentally been left behind. A third account reports that the woman was already on board one of the boats when she discovered that her child was missing and that she jumped overboard and swam ashore; due to the rising storm, the *Peor es Nada* was forced to sail without her (Hardacre 1880; Nidever 1937:37-38; Woodward 1957:255-256; Phelps 1961).

The Nicoleño refugees were taken to San Pedro and from there to Los Angeles and San Gabriel. One Nicoleño, a man nicknamed Black Hawk, had suffered head injuries in skirmishes with the Russian Indians; he remained in San Pedro, living on the beach with a group of hunters. Two of the women reportedly married wealthy men in Los Angeles. According to the existing accounts, all but two of the Nicoleño died soon after reaching the mainland. Black Hawk was blinded by disease while living in San Pedro; he later fell from a steep bank and drowned in the ocean. He may have been buried on Deadman's Island, which was a prominent landmark at the entrance to San Pedro Harbor until it was removed during harbor expansion in the years 1927 to 1929 (Warner 1856; Hardacre 1880; Nidever 1937:38; Woodward

1957:254; Gleason 1958:115-116; Phelps 1961; Queenan 1986:91).

The *Peor es Nada* was scheduled to return to San Nicolas and rescue the Indian woman; however, several prior commitments intervened. During one of these voyages, while hauling a load of lumber to San Francisco the vessel capsized at the entrance to the Golden Gate. The crew reached the shore safely, but the vessel was lost at sea. As there was no other ship on the west coast capable of making the trip to San Nicolas, all plans of rescuing the Nicoleño girl were abandoned.

Fifteen years passed before another attempt was made to locate the Indian woman. In 1850, a Californian named Thomas Jeffries came into possession of a small sailing vessel. Jeffries was reportedly paid \$200 by Father Gonzales of Mission Santa Barbara to sail to San Nicolas and find the Indian girl or her child. The search was unsuccessful; however, Jeffries apparently restricted his efforts to a cursory search of the island's beaches and made no attempt to investigate the interior (Hardacre 1880; Hudson 1981:189-190).

Despite his failure, Jeffries returned to Santa Barbara with glowing tales of the herds of seal and sea otter that he had observed near San Nicolas. His stories caught the attention of George Nidever, a fur trapper and adventurer who had come to California in 1833 with the Joseph Reddeford Walker Party, and together they planned a trip to the island in Nidever's schooner (Hardacre 1880; Nidever 1937:77; Woodward 1957:257).

In April of 1852, Nidever and Jeffries sailed to San Nicolas to hunt and gather seagull eggs, which at that time were in great demand. While on the island, the two men discovered footprints in soft soil near a cluster of small brush enclosures a short distance from the beach. Nearby, strips of seal blubber dried in the open air, suspended from poles driven into the ground. These discoveries convinced Nidever that the Nicoleño girl was alive; however, the onset of a fierce gale prevented any further search. The schooner was forced to lie off San Nicolas for eight days. It finally made a run to Santa Barbara Island and thence to the mainland. An Indian crewman aboard the schooner claimed to have seen a woman running along the shore during the storm, beckoning and shouting to the sailors (Hardacre 1880; Nidever 1937:77-78).

Nidever made his second trip to San Nicolas in the winter of 1852. He was accompanied on this trip by Carl Dittman, who was also known by the nickname "Charlie Brown." Several new discoveries were made during this voyage. Dittman found a set of footprints on the beach, but unfortunately the trail disappeared where it crossed a moss-covered bank. He also found a piece of driftwood that had been accidentally dropped beside a trail.

Together, Nidever and Dittman discovered a basket lodged in the crotch of a high bush. The basket was covered with a piece of sealskin and inside was an assortment of bone needles, sinew rope, and skins of the shag, a small cormorant. The men scattered these articles upon the ground in the hope that the owner would replace them and thereby give proof of her presence. They then began hunting otter, but three or four days later were again driven from the island by foul weather, running to San Miguel Island and thence to the mainland (Nidever 1937:79-80; Dittman 1961).

The following summer, Nidever, Dittman, and an Irishman nicknamed "Colorado" travelled to San Nicolas, accompanied by four Mission Indians from Santa Barbara. One of these Indians has been identified as a Ventureño Chumash hunter named Melquiaries *Shustu*. When the party arrived at San Nicolas, fresh footprints were discovered in wet soil surrounding Old Garden Spring, located near the beach on the north shore of the island. It was already late in the day when the discovery was made, so a thorough search was postponed until the following morning (Nidever 1937:80-81; Woodward 1957:260; Hudson 1981:190).

The next day the search began in earnest. The men formed two groups, Nidever and Dittman in one, Colorado and three of the Indians in the other. Colorado and the Indians rediscovered the basket that Nidever and Dittman had found on the previous trip, the contents of which had been carefully replaced. Meanwhile, Nidever and Dittman worked their way toward the northwest end of the island. While Nidever stopped for a short rest, Dittman continued on toward the island's tip, where he began climbing a long slope (Nidever 1937:81; Woodward 1957:260-261).

When Dittman reached the ridge he paused to catch his breath, allowing his gaze to wander across the landscape. In the distance he spotted a small,

black dot which seemed to be moving; he imagined it was a crow sitting on a bush. His curiosity piqued, he advanced cautiously. As he drew closer he realized that he was seeing the head and shoulders of an Indian woman above the low walls of a whale bone hut. He had found the Lone Woman of San Nicolas!

When Dittman came upon the woman she was skinning a seal with a knife made from a piece of iron hoop hafted in a wooden handle. She talked to herself continuously as she worked, occasionally pausing to follow the progress of the search party, which she could clearly see from her position. Near the house were several dogs. They growled at Dittman as he approached, but the woman sent them away with a yell, unaware of the man's presence. Dittman signaled to the men in the search party by removing the ramrod from his rifle and using it to raise his hat, and they quickly surrounded the house (Nidever 1937:81-82; Woodward 1957:261; Dittman 1961).

When Nidever reached the ridge he found the other men seated around the woman. He described her as about 50 years of age, of medium height, and rather thick in build. Her hair, once black, was now thickly matted and bleached to a dull brown color. Her features were pleasant, but her teeth were worn to the gums, probably from chewing grit mixed with food prepared in stone mortars. Such tooth wear was common in Indian populations prior to the adoption of a European diet. She wore a single, sleeveless garment sewn from shag (cormorant) skins, which fitted close at the neck and reached almost to her feet. The garment was girded at the waist with a sinew cord. A second, similar dress was stored in a basket nearby (Nidever 1937:83-84; Woodward 1957:264).

The woman's home, a roofless house located near the best spring of water and the best spot for taking fish and seal, commanded a good view of most of the island. Outside the house were several baskets, some unfinished, and two tarred water bottles, as well as an assortment of bone needles, fishhooks, and sinew cords. Blubber hung from stakes and from a sinew rope stretched between two poles. During the rainy season, a nearby cave provided a dry shelter (Nidever 1937:84).

The woman served her guests a meal of roots, which she roasted in the fire burning within the hut, and then accompanied them back to the schooner. The men helped carry her personal possessions, which had been loaded into baskets. They stopped at a spring

near the beach so the woman could wash herself, then proceeded to the ship. In place of her feather garment Dittman sewed her a petticoat of cotton ticking, which she wore with a man's cotton shirt and a black necktie (Nidever 1937:84-85).

The Indian woman lived at the camp on the beach for the next month while the men hunted. During this time she supplied the men with water and firewood and worked on her baskets. The hunters made a toy for her by stuffing a dead sea otter pup and hanging it by a string from the ceiling of her shelter. She amused herself by lying on her back and swinging it overhead (Nidever 1937:86).

When the hunt was complete the party set sail for the mainland, but en route they encountered yet another of the storms so frequent near San Nicolas. The woman dropped to her knees while facing the wind, apparently praying to bring the storm to an end. She repeated this behavior several times that day, and seemed quite satisfied when the storm subsided (Nidever 1937:87).

When the schooner reached Santa Barbara a variety of new experiences awaited the Nicoleño woman. She was especially delighted by the sight of an oxcart and a man on horseback. She lived with the Nidever family and received a steady stream of guests. Indians from Ventura, Santa Barbara, and Santa Ynez tried conversing with her; however, it was reported that none could understand her language. Unsuccessful attempts were also made to speak to her in Fernandean and Catalineño (Hardacre 1880; Kroeber 1925:634; Nidever 1937:87-88; Woodward 1957:266-267; Hudson 1981:194). Four of her words were recorded: "*to-co* (reportedly pronounced *to-kay*)" for hide; "*nache* (*nah'-chey*)" for man; "*te-gua* (*taý-gwah*)" for sky; and "*pínche* (*pin-oo-chey*)" for body (Hardacre 1880). On the basis of these words Kroeber suggested that the woman's language was Shoshonean, or Uto-Aztecan, although the dialect could not be established (Kroeber 1925:633; see also Munro 1994).

The woman frequently sang and danced for her hosts, and four of her songs, or perhaps two different versions of the same two songs, were memorized by Melquiáres Shustu. Later, these songs were passed on to Fernando Librado, a Ventureño Chumash, and were recorded on wax cylinders by Harrington in 1913 (Hudson 1981:191, 194; see also Munro 1994).

The woman's time following her arrival in Santa

Barbara was all too brief. Her fondness for unfamiliar foods, such as green corn, vegetables, and fresh fruits, provoked attacks of dysentery, and a fall from the Nidever's porch left her with an injured spine. In addition, she became depressed when none of her kinsmen could be found. On Tuesday, October 18, 1853, seven weeks after arriving in Santa Barbara, the Lone Woman of San Nicolas died. She was christened Juana María on her deathbed, and her body was buried in the Nidever family plot in the cemetery at Santa Barbara Mission (Hardacre 1880; Woodward 1957:267-268).

Juana María's death did not dispel the aura of mystery surrounding her story, however. All of the objects brought to the mainland at the time of her rescue have since disappeared. The lost items include a feather dress, a feather cape, sandals, necklaces, fishhooks, a stone mortar, and tarred water bottles. She gave many of the smaller objects as gifts to people in Santa Barbara; the feather dress was reportedly sent to Rome by the priests at the mission, but it has never been located. Many, perhaps most, of her possessions were housed in the California Academy of Sciences in San Francisco and were burned in the great fire that followed the 1906 earthquake (Woodward 1957:268-269; Heizer 1960; Hudson 1981:195-197; Geiger n.d.:13). A photograph of a tarred water bottle reportedly made by Juana María appears in Chapter 7.

Two final notes bring to a close the strange, sad story of Juana María. Her exact place of burial in the Santa Barbara Mission cemetery is unmarked, but in 1928 a bronze plaque commemorating her life was placed on the back wall of the mission tower near the cemetery (Geiger n.d.:13-14). Eleven years later, in 1939, an archaeological expedition sponsored by the Natural History Museum of Los Angeles County visited San Nicolas Island. Using Nidever's account as a guide, the members retraced the route followed by Dittman and Nidever and rediscovered what they believed to be the remains of Juana María's whale bone hut. On a second trip, in 1940, the fragments of the house were re-erected. Years later, one member of the party returned to find the walls of the house fallen, the whale bone slowly weathering into the soil (Woodward 1957:262-264; Morgan 1979).